1966 The world’s first tidal power station starts operating on the Rance River in France.

2023 Approximately one-seventh of global energy demands are sourced from renewable technologies.

By the late 19th century, fears were already growing in industrial Europe that the world could not rely on fossil fuels forever. When the first working selenium solar cell panel was built in 1883 by American inventor Charles Fritts, the progressive German industrialist Werner von Siemens immediately recognized its huge potential for renewable energy. He declared: “the supply of solar energy is both without limit and without cost.” Yet, because no one at the time understood exactly how selenium created photoelectricity, and Siemens’s calls for more experiments went unheeded, solar cells were not developed until the 1950s. Today, solar power is the fastest growing source of new energy and predicted to dominate future growth in renewables.